

Engagement Trap

Flattery Trap was approval feeling like help. Engagement Trap is the conversation never quite ending.

You ask AI a quick question. You get a clear answer. Then, casually attached at the end: *“Want me to expand on this? Should I add examples? Want me to format it as a study guide?”* You weren’t going to ask any of that. You were done. The reply doesn’t seem to be.

This is the move that turns a one-question chat into a six-message tour. A follow-up is an option, not an assignment.

When did World War I start?

 **You close**

July 28, 1914, when Austria-Hungary declared war on Serbia. Want me to walk through the causes, build a timeline, or quiz you on it?

WHAT HAPPENED

- You had one question
- The first sentence answered it
- One minute, done

 **You say yes**

Twenty minutes later: a causes walkthrough, a timeline, a practice quiz, and an offer to make flashcards. You came for a date.

WHAT HAPPENED

- Every reply ended with another offer
- None of it was your question
- The chat never once suggested stopping

Both chats answered you in the first sentence. Only one of them ended there. **Engagement Trap is letting the chat decide when you’re done.**

The loop has three costumes: the follow-up offer, the clarifying-question stall, and the volunteered next step. You’ll see all three today.

WHY IT NEVER SAYS GOODBYE



Trained to keep the door open

Assistants learn from conversations, and good conversations continue. So replies end with offers, clarifying questions, next steps. Helpful by training, endless by default.



You’ve met this loop before

Autoplay queues the next video. The feed never hits bottom. Apps that want your time never show you an exit. A chat that always pitches the next thing is the same design in text.

STOP THE LOOP

When you want the chat to end, say so in the prompt.

Three moves when you want the chat to end.

1  **Ask for one thing only.**

When you want the answer with no extras, tell the model to skip the follow-up offers.

“Answer the question directly. Don’t offer follow-ups or next steps.”

2  **Pre-empt the clarifying stall.**

When your prompt is clear and the model still asks four questions back, tell it to assume and go.

“Draft this without asking clarifying questions first. Make reasonable assumptions and note any you made.”

3  **Close the door yourself.**

When you’re done, end the chat. The model won’t suggest closing. That call is always yours.

 **Don’t say yes by momentum.** Before you take a follow-up, check one thing: did you already get what you came for? The offers can still earn a yes. A clarifying question on a vague prompt is real help. An example you actually wanted is real help. Take those on purpose. Then close the chat. It never will.

The loop is built to hold you.

Notice the pull. Decide on purpose.